

DEEP SCRUTINY People queue at a block office to update voter ID cards amid SIR fears, North 24 Parganas, West Bengal, Sept. 9

THE COUNT OF ILLEGALS

1997: Home minister Indrajit Gupta estimates 10 million illegal immigrants

2001: A task force on Border Management (during BJP rule) raises count it to 15 million

2004: Congress minister Sriprakash Jaiswal tells Parliament there are 12 million Bangladeshis in India

2016: MoS for home affairs Kiren Rijiju makes a claim of "around 20 million" illegal immigrants in India

2019: Assam's NRC excludes 1.9 million who could not prove their citizenship

- Also, the 2002-03 revision was done from scratch, but the 2025 exercise discriminates between voters based on when they were enrolled, creating different documentary requirements for different cohorts
- Those who appeared on the 2003 rolls, roughly 49.6 million people, need to submit only an enumeration form with an extract from that old list, which has been made available online
- But the remaining 29.3 million face steeper requirements. Voters aged above 40 and missing from the 2003 list have to provide documentary proof of their citizenship, identity and residence. Those born between Jul. 1, 1987, and Dec. 2, 2004, must provide proof of their date and place of birth plus similar documentation for one parent. Those born after December 2004 need proof for themselves and both parents
- The ECI initially specified 11 acceptable documents, excluding Aadhaar, PAN and voter ID because, as officials explained, they did not prove citizenship. After an SC directive, Aadhaar was accepted as the 12th document, but additional documentation may be asked for, in order to authenticate it

mographic change since the 2011 Census," says Prof. Saswati Choudhury, director of the OKD Institute of Social Change and Development, Guwahati. "In the absence of such data, it is impossible to draw firm conclusions about how much of the population increase is due to births, recorded migration or other unexplained factors. The politics of demography will remain a contentious fault line in India, given the polarised socio-political landscape and the salience of religious identities. The immediate priority, therefore, is to conduct the next Census to provide a reliable picture."

The Mandate of a Mission

Population experts stress that the proposed demography mission must acknowledge development as the strongest safeguard of national security. Ram B. Bhagat, author of *Population & the Political Imagination: Census, Register & Citizenship in India* and former professor at the International Institute for Population Sciences, says the mission should not limit itself to infiltration but also examine the out-migration of citizens from border states and districts. "Understanding demographic change requires more than counting heads," he says. "It demands systematic data on birth and death rates, health conditions, employment opportunities and access to basic amenities." Prof. Choudhury agrees, arguing that the mission must go beyond raw numbers and place population growth and shifts in religious composition within the larger socioeconomic realities, particularly in regions where growth is most pronounced.

In the end, Modi's demography mission is less a settled policy than an unsettled question: is citizenship in India to be anchored in fairness and inclusion, or in suspicion and exclusion? The government has armed itself with sweeping new laws, but history, from Assam's failed NRC to Bihar's contested roll revision, shows the dangers of reducing identity to documents and politics. Whether this mission steadies the Republic or further fractures it will depend on whether it treats demography as data to be weaponised, or as a reality to be governed with fairness, nuance and humanity. ■